EW 13 POUVOIR

82. POUVOIR The verb *pouvoir* implies:

A.	PHYSICAL ABILITY	I can lift this stone	= am able to
		Je peux soulever cette pierre	
B.	PERMISSION	You may take off your coat now	= are allowed to
		Tu peux enlever ta jaquette maintenant	
C.	POSSIBILITY	It may rain tonight	= perhaps
		Il peut pleuvoir ce soir	

The cardinal rule is that POUVOIR (PU) is always followed by a present infinitive

If you are translating one of the following English structures the tense of *pouvoir* in French will always be the one that is shown:

Simple tenses

I can / may/ am able to/ am allowed to	**je peux**	PRESENT TENSE
I could / might / was able to/ was allowed to	**je pouvais**	IMPERFECT TENSE
I will be able to / will be allowed to	**je pourrai**	FUTURE TENSE
I could / might / would be able to /would be allowed to	**je pourrais**	CONDITIONAL

I can carry this, you cannot	*je peux porter ceci, toi tu ne peux pas*
She may go out in the evenings until 10 o'clock	*elle peut sortir le soir jusqu'à 10 heures*
He will be able to do it tomorrow	*il pourra le faire demain*
You will be allowed to smoke when you are 18	*tu pourras fumer quand tu auras 18 ans*
He could do it if he wanted	*il pourrait le faire s'il voulait*
You might try something else	*tu pourrais essayer autre chose*

Compound tenses

I have been able / may have	**j'ai pu**	PERFECT TENSE
I had been able / might have / could have	**j'avais pu**	PLUPERFECT TENSE
I could have / might have / would have been allowed	**j'aurais pu**	CONDITIONAL PERFECT

We have been able to help them	*nous avons pu les aider*
She may have rung last night	*elle a pu téléphoner hier soir*
If I had been able to do it I would have done it	*si j'avais pu le faire je l'aurais fait*
She might have done it but I wasn't sure	*elle avait pu le faire mais je n'étais pas sûr*

They could have travelled all night	*ils auraient pu voyager toute la nuit*
if they had wanted to	*s'ils l'avaient voulu*
I would have been allowed to go out	*j'aurais pu sortir*
if I had finished my homework	*si j'avais fini mes devoirs*

Can . . . & May . . . are always in the present tense

Could . . . & Might . . . may be either in the imperfect or the conditional

Here, the easiest way to deal with `could' or `might', and decide which tense of **pouvoir** to use, is to replace it with the appropriate part of the verb `to be able' `to be allowed to'.

83. Note the following refinements

a) to translate `could have', `might have' in expressions of age or distance

- use the IMPERFECT

He could have been twenty	*il pouvait avoir vingt ans*
It might have been 15 kilometres away	*il pouvait se trouver à 15 kilomètres*

b) when `may' or `might' record or express possibility you can avoid using *pouvoir* by using:

- *peut-être*, but note carefully where it is placed in the sentence:

He may arrive this evening		*peut-être qu'il arrivera ce soir*
	or	*il arrivera peut-être ce soir*
	or	*peut-être arrivera-t-il ce soir*

- *il se peut que* + SUBJUNCTIVE

He may arrive this evening	*il se peut qu'il arrive ce soir*

c) Cases where `can' & `could' may NOT be translated by pouvoir

the present & imperfect tenses of *pouvoir* may NOT be used:

- with *comprendre*
- with verbs of perception (*voir, entendre, sentir, distinguer* [= to make out])

CAN is simply the present tense of the verb; COULD = simply the imperfect tense of the verb

- I can't (couldn't) see them : *Je ne les vois pas (Je ne les voyais pas)*
- He (can't) couldn't understand why : *Il ne (comprend) comprenait pas pourquoi*

d) When `can' means having the necessary KNOWLEDGE OR SKILL to do something as opposed to the necessary physical strength

- use *savoir*
- I can drive/play the piano/swim : *Je sais conduire/jouer du piano/nager*

Contrast this with *Je ne peux pas conduire parce que j'ai la jambe cassée* where *pouvoir* must be used because there is a physical impediment

84. Some verbs in French require the insertion of DE before a noun

to remember someone/something	**se souvenir de**	to depend on s.o/s.thing	**dépendre de**
to use something	**se servir de**	to laugh at someone/something	**rire de**
to approach someone/something	**s'approcher de**	to do without something	**se passer de**
to thank someone for something	**remercier qn de**	to distrust someone/something	**se méfier de**
to apologise for something	**s'excuser de**	to make fun of someone	**se moquer de**
to look after someone/something	**s'occuper de**	to take advantage of	**profiter de**
to pity someone	**avoir pitié de**	to play (an instrument)	**jouer de**
to think about (opinion)	**penser de**		

When using pronouns with these verbs you must distinguish between PEOPLE and THINGS

i) referring to things `it' / `them' = **en** [NB there is no past participle agreement after *en*]
- He thanked him for them : *Il l'en a remercié*
- I did without it : *Je m'en suis passé*

ii) referring to people : **de moi - de toi - de lui/d'elle - de nous - de vous - d'eux/d'elles**
- I went up to her : *Je me suis approché d'elle*
- They laughed at us : *Ils ont ri de nous*
- What do you think of him? : *Qu'est-ce que vous pensez de lui?*

When translating `WHICH' or `WHOM' with the verbs listed above use *dont* [never use *qui* or *que*]

- The people I depend on : *Les gens dont je dépends*
- They're the books he used : *Ce sont les livres dont il s'est servi*
- The city we were approaching : *La ville dont nous nous approchions*